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Gal Hirsch vindicated at last

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Author: GREER FAY CASHMAN | Section: Features | 3477 Words
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Once considered to be a brilliant military commander, Brig.-Gen. (ret.) Gal Hirsch has finally been vindicated.

Hirsch, who commanded the 91st Division of the IDF during the Second Lebanon War (2006), was held responsible for the abduction of Israeli reservists Ehud Goldwasser and Eldad Regev, who were captured and killed the day before they were due to complete their service.

Hirsch, who had ambitions to one day be IDF chief of staff, based on his reputation as an outstanding commanding officer, saw his hopes in that direction dashed when an IDF commission of inquiry headed by Maj.-Gen. (ret.) Doron Almog, who is currently chairman of the Jewish Agency, determined that Hirsch was responsible not only for the abduction, but also for several other military failures. Almog recommended that Hirsch be relieved of his command role and that he should not be promoted.

Subsequent to that, judge Eliyahu Winograd, who headed a commission appointed by the government to probe the Second Lebanon War, decided that Hirsch had been treated unjustly, and had been forced out of the army. Hirsch returned to serve under Benny Gantz, who was then IDF chief of staff.

In 2015, when Gilad Erdan was public security minister, he decided to appoint Hirsch as Israel Police commissioner, a move that did not earn him brownie points with senior officers in the police force who resented the intrusion of an outsider. Just before the matter of his appointment was concluded, Hirsch was charged with serious tax evasion, a factor that blew his chances of becoming the top honcho in the police force. Fighting to clear his name, Hirsch eventually succeeded, but it was too late for him to become police commissioner.

Meanwhile, he has been a successful businessman and author, and has also had a finger in the political pie.

His appointment this week as hostage coordinator will afford him the chance to once again prove what a creative mind he has. He immediately entered his new role with full steam, swearing to bring home the hostages being held by Hamas, and to find the people who are missing. His office, he said, would work in the most effective way.

However, he postponed meeting with anxious parents.

Attorney Uri Slonim, who was the longtime coordinator and negotiator for Israeli hostages and Israelis missing in action, wrote a book on the subject, A Knock on the Door, which tells the story of his clandestine work in searching for, and sometimes finding, his quarries, albeit not always alive.

As for Erdan, as a native son of Ashkelon, it must be agonizing for him at this moment to be sitting in New York as Israel’s permanent representative to the United Nations, while Ashkelon is under attack from Hamas.

* SWORDS OF Iron, the war currently raging between Israel and Hamas, has been compared to the Yom Kippur War and to 9/11, and more recently to the Holocaust by former US ambassador David Friedman. In an interview with American radio host Mark Levin about the present situation in the Middle East, specifically the war between Israel and Hamas, Friedman said: “We have seen some of the most barbaric acts since the Holocaust.”

President Isaac Herzog, in a video address to the international community on Monday, as well as in the current issue of Time magazine, also compared the brutality of Hamas with that of the Nazis during the Holocaust.

“Not since the Holocaust have we witnessed scenes of Jewish women and children, grandparents – even Holocaust survivors – being herded into trucks and taken into captivity,” he said in his videotaped address to the international community on Monday.

Herzog also compared Hamas with ISIS, saying that Hamas has imported, adopted, and replicated the savagery of ISIS, entering civilian homes on a holy day and murdering in cold blood whole families – young and old – violating and burning bodies, beating and torturing their innocent victims, Jews and Muslims and members of other faiths.

Between addresses to the nation and the international community, Herzog has been visiting some of the wounded at the Shamir Medical Center on Sunday and the Soroka Medical Center in Beersheba on Monday. He suggested that if anyone wants to see the great spirit of Israel, they can see it in hospitals throughout the country, where there are people united and committed to prevail together and to come out victorious.

* THE REPEATED assertions by Herzog, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, Defense Minister Yoav Gallant, as well as opposition leaders Yair Lapid and Benny Gantz, that Israel will emerge victorious from this war do not serve to assuage the concerns of parents and grandparents who have children and grandchildren currently serving in the IDF. It’s bad enough when they have to worry about only one child or grandchild in the army, but Michael Bliss of Netanya, who came on aliyah from Britain 17 years ago, is worried about not only one of his grandchildren, but six who were all called up on active duty following the Hamas invasion of southern Jewish communities on Saturday. Bliss is not only a grandfather, but also a great-grandfather to 42 of his progeny. Fortunately, most of his great-grandchildren are too young to serve, but Bliss is quite proud of the fact that he has grandsons who serve in reserve naval combat units.

* ON THE subject of grandfathers and great-grandfathers (and mothers), Adopt-A-Safta, which translates as adopt a grandmother, was founded by American immigrant Jay M. Shultz, the president of the Tel Aviv-headquartered Am Yisrael Foundation, which encourages English-speaking young immigrant men and women to become weekly companions to Holocaust survivors and other senior citizens. Very often, the survivors are living alone, and the young people who come to be with them, listen to their stories, take them for a walk or do their shopping for them are the highlight of their week. Sometimes, a strong bond is formed between the young person and the survivor, and their meetings become more frequent.

A businessman and philanthropist, Shultz, who has been living in Israel since 2006, has made it his mission in life to help young men and women from English-speaking countries adjust to life in Israel, by providing them with various groups that participate in cultural, political, and religious affairs, enabling them to get a grasp of life in Israel in its variety, as well as to network along the way.

Shultz is particularly concerned with the well-being of senior citizens, especially now, and is calling for volunteers to help with food deliveries to isolated elderly people. Acts of kindness and financial help can be registered with the foundation.

* NOTHING HAS been more heart-wrenching than to hear the tear-filled voices of mothers and fathers whose sons and daughters have either been abducted or have gone missing without a trace. It is just as hard on grandparents, particularly those who have already known bereavement, such as Yosef Engel of Kibbutz Ramat Rachel, whose grandson Ofir Engel was kidnapped when he visited his girlfriend at Kibbutz Beeri last weekend. Hamas confiscated the phones of the entire family, which means that Engel and his relatives have had no contact with Ofir since his abduction. Anyone who has any information about him is asked to telephone 050-620-5101.

Yosef Engel lost his son St.-Sgt. Yair Engel in a diving accident in Haifa in December 1996. After that Yosef extended his name to include that of his son, and is known as Yosef Avi Yair Engel. Yosef Avi Yair Engel is a member of the board of directors of the Peres Center for Peace and Innovation. During the period in which Shimon Peres was president of the state, Engel worked with him very closely and accompanied him on his trips abroad. A photographer by profession, with other concurrent careers, he has photographed many historic events and iconic individuals.

ONE CANNOT help but weep over the cruel and senseless deaths of Itai and Hadas Berdichevsky (both 30), who bravely shielded their 10-month-old twins in a shelter as terrorists invaded their home in Kibbutz Kfar Aza in southern Israel.

Their babies remained undiscovered and alone for approximately 12-14 agonizing hours before they were rescued to grow up as orphans. At that age, they will have no memory of their biological parents as they grow older, which magnifies an already profoundly tragic situation.

* JUST ABOUT everywhere in the Western world where Jews have settled, Palestinians have also settled, and therefore the Middle East conflict is carried to other countries and continents. Whenever and wherever there is a pro-Israel rally, there is also a pro-Palestinian rally. This was particularly obvious in recent days in rallies in New York, London, Paris, Buenos Aires, Sydney, and elsewhere.

While it is perfectly legitimate for Palestinian expatriates to campaign for Palestinian self-determination and a two-state solution to the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, it is not legitimate for them to sing and dance and celebrate murder with fireworks, as happened in Sydney this week. There is something terribly immoral about celebrating the deaths of innocent civilians, including children, women, and senior citizens. In Jewish tradition, while taught to remember what Amalek did to the Children of Israel, and to ensure that it does not happen again, there is no joy when innocent people, especially children, are killed in the course of Israeli airstrikes in Gaza. In fact, such operations are sometimes criticized in the Israeli media, and sympathetic reports are published about the victims.

Though supportive of Israel in the current crisis, Australian Minister for Foreign Affairs Penny Wong, urged both sides to exercise restraint with the aim of protecting civilian lives. Many more Israelis have been killed than Palestinians, but in each case, the numbers are in the hundreds, and each exceeds by more than double the number of Arabs who have killed each other in Israel over the past nine months.

* WHILE THE Australian government has expressed its support for Israel, Palestinians living in Lakemba and Greenacres in Sydney celebrated the Hamas attack with singing, dancing, and fireworks. The celebration was condemned by the Australian Jewish Association, whose weekly lectures on issues pertaining to Australia’s Jewish community and to Israel have enabled it to evolve into a powerful voice for Australian Jewry and for Israel.

The Sydney Opera House and iconic landmarks in 12 Melbourne municipalities were lit up in the blue and white colors of Israel’s national flag this week, as was 10 Downing Street in London. The Australian branch of the international Palestine Action Network held a rally at Sydney Town Hall in which participants called for a free Palestine.

Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese has promised Australians living in or visiting Israel that the federal government of Australia will provide whatever support they need. In a radio interview this week, he voiced concern for Australians in Israel, adding: “What we saw on the weekend was unprecedented.” He said that the detainment in Gaza of [Israeli] citizens, including women and children, “is just completely unacceptable.”

While reiterating his support for a two-state solution to the conflict, Albanese emphasized that what occurred over the last weekend “is completely indefensible.”

* IN LONDON, British Prime Minister Rishi Sumak declared that Britain unequivocally stands with Israel and offered Netanyahu “any support that Israel needs.” As was the case with the Australian government, Sumak also urged restraint on both sides.

Together with UK Chief Rabbi Sir Ephraim Mirvis, Sumak on Monday participated in a rally at the Finchley United Synagogue, where he reiterated Britain’s support for Israel.

* IN THE United States presidential candidate Nikki Haley said that the attack was not just against Israel, it was also an attack against America. “They hate us just as much.” She advised Netanyahu “to finish them. They should have hell to pay for what they’ve just done.” She emphasized that America should unite around Israel, making sure that

“our enemies should not hurt our friends.”

* MORE OFTEN than not, America and Americans are among the first to render assistance to Israel in times of crisis. This should never be taken for granted, yet it comes as no surprise that the UJA Federation of New York, presided over by Linda Mirels and chaired by Mac Rowan, instantly allocated an initial $10 million in emergency funding from its endowment to provide immediate relief to victims of the vicious Hamas attacks. In addition, the UJA-Federation also launched an Israel Emergency Fund.

Recognizing the importance of solidarity, the UJA-Federation, together with the Jewish Community Relations Council of New York (JCRC-NY), as well as ADL-NY, AJC-NY, the American Zionist Movement, the Association of Reform Zionists of America and COJECO organized a vigil and rally that took place on Tuesday afternoon at Dag Hammarskjold Plaza in Manhattan.

* ON THE other side of the continent, in California, Gov. Gavin Newsom signed into law Assembly Bill 1185, authored by Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel (D-San Fernando Valley). The bill, which is a top priority for the Jewish Public Affairs Committee, expands the eligibility for the California State Nonprofit Security Grant Program to include “community connectors,” nonprofits like Jewish Federations that play a critical role in ensuring the safety of a large network of at-risk institutions. It passed both houses of the legislature with unanimous, bipartisan support.

“There are community support organizations that play a critical role in ensuring the safety of a large network of at-risk nonprofits,” said David Bocarsly, JPAC’s executive director. “Expanding the Nonprofit Security Grant Program to support the security training, vulnerability assessments, and monitoring and response systems that Jewish Federations and other community connectors provide will make this already vital program that much more impactful.

“It’s unfortunate that security infrastructure has become so important, but we are deeply grateful to Assembly member Gabriel for continuing to shape and reshape this program to most effectively serve Jewish and all vulnerable communities, and to Gov. Newsom for his consistent support.”

JPAC was the lead sponsor of the bill, with critical support from the Jewish Federation of Greater Los Angeles, the San Francisco-based Jewish Community Federation and Endowment Fund, and JCRC Bay Area. JPAC also organized 31 Jewish organizations to sign on in support, and it became a priority for the California Legislative Jewish Caucus, which Gabriel cochairs.

“We are thrilled that Gov. Newsom has signed this important piece of legislation,” said Rabbi Noah Farkas, president and CEO of the Jewish Federation of Greater Los Angeles. “This bill will allow our federation’s security work, led by our community security initiative and our partners across the state, to better protect countless community members.”

Joy Sisisky, CEO, Jewish Community Federation and Endowment Fund, echoed the sentiments expressed by her colleagues. “As antisemitism persists at historically high levels, including in the Bay Area, we are grateful to Gov. Gavin Newsom, Assembly member Jesse Gabriel and the California Legislature for the Nonprofit Security Grant Program, which will enhance the federation’s security trainings, consultations, and other vital assistance to the Jewish community.”

* BECAUSE THE source of the article published in The Jerusalem Post on Tuesday about Claudia Goldin, who is only the third woman ever to win the Nobel Prize for economics was Reuters and not JTA, it did not state that she is Jewish.

However, it was stated in the Hebrew press whose article was from another source, which also mentioned her husband, fellow economist Lawrence Katz.

Of the two previous female laureates, Elinor Ostram was the daughter of a Jewish father, Esther Duflo, a French-American economist, has been careful to avoid any mention of her religion in her biographical notes, as have her

parents, who each have strong academic backgrounds, but most of Duflo's close academic associates are Jewish.

* DUE To the security situation and in respect for the many bereaved families who have suffered tragic losses in the deaths of loved ones who fell in defense of the country or who were murdered by Hamas, the Ben-Zvi Institute has postponed or canceled events scheduled for October. Among them are a Yemenite Festival, which included a lecture on the Yemenite Jews of Jerusalem, which was scheduled for Thursday, October 12, and an in-depth seminar on the 50th anniversary of the Yom Kippur War, which was due to take place on Tuesday, October 17.

In connection with the Yom Kippur War, one of its heroes, Brig.-Gen. (ret.) Avigdor Kahalani has been endlessly interviewed on electronic media and asked for comparisons between the surprise attacks of 1973 and 2023.

* ISRAELIS RESPOND amazingly well to emergency situations. This can be seen in the number of instant organizational efforts to collect provisions and funds for soldiers and evacuated civilians, and accommodating evacuees in hotels. But these are not the only examples.

When the call went out for blood donations to ensure that there would be sufficient blood available for transfusions that might be needed in treating the hundreds of people wounded in Hamas attacks, the response was so great that people had to be turned away because it was impossible to deal with so many donors in a single day.

A more organized blood donation drive has been scheduled for Monday, October 23, between 10 a.m. and 2 p.m., in a cooperative campaign by Magen David Adom and Ben & Jerry's ice cream. This is not the first time they have come together for the purpose of a blood donation campaign. Ben & Jerry's booths will be stationed alongside MDA vehicles in which people can donate blood, and all donors will receive free ice cream in a choice of flavors.

Most needed are people with type O blood, but donors from other blood groups will be welcomed. Blood donations can be given at universities, colleges, and shopping malls. For further details access http://www.mdais.org/dam or telephone (03) 530-0400.

* AMONG THOSE working the hardest during the current crisis is ZAKA, the search and rescue organization, which, among its various activities, places priority on identifying bodies and matching them to body parts discovered after a terrorist attack or a serious traffic accident, and matching them to the deceased in order to be able to have as proper a Jewish burial as possible.

ZAKA has faced one of its most traumatic periods over the past few days, given the high death toll. In order to fully continue its work, it requires funds and has mounted a campaign to this effect, asking prospective donors to give $360 or the equivalent to ensure that each victim receives a proper halachic burial.

* ZAKA is a voluntary organization, most of whose members belong to various haredi communities, and are not necessarily Zionists. But whatever anti-Zionist feelings they have are put on the back burner as they diligently work to rescue people, to identify dead bodies and prepare them for burial, and also work with people experiencing trauma. The fact that they have cooperated with paramedic units of the IDF should indicate to politicians such as Yitzchak Goldknopf, Meir Porush, Moshe Gafni, and Yisrael Eichler that there is value in giving service to the state on a humane level. The abovementioned are using all the resources at their disposal to keep haredi young men out of the IDF, and so far have refused the civilian option of having them give two years of service to various community and national needs.

In Jewish law, the saving of life supersedes every other law, including those related to Sabbath and Yom Kippur. The police force is desperately in need of additional human resources, especially among traffic police. There are so many traffic violations by riders of electric scooters, motorbikes, and bicycles, not to mention the number of jaywalkers, that additional traffic police are urgently needed to reduce such infractions and thereby prevent accidents and fatalities.

* NO MATTER how bad and how negative things are, those who look for it can always find a silver lining. Since Saturday, there have been many social media reunions among families, friends, and old schoolmates, who may not

have been in touch for years, or who contact each other only on birthdays, milestone wedding anniversaries, and just before Rosh Hashanah. Now, everyone is anxious to know whether people with whom they share some history are safe.

* THERE ARE numerous support groups for people who are afraid, ill, have a disability, or are simply in need of company. Lists where help can be found have been compiled by the Association of Americans and Canadians in Israel, Telfed, the Israel Office of the Zionist Federation of Australia, Nefesh B'Nefesh, and even Jon Medved, the founder of OurCrowd. The lists with contact details are available on the websites of all of the above. Everyone is trying to do something to help, not just in Israel, and not just among Jews.

Hopefully, that spirit will be maintained after the war is over.

greerfc@gmail.com

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